

CHRISCO DIGITAL ACADEMY

The Practical Handbook Series

Print on Demand

Sell custom-designed products worldwide - with zero inventory.

You will choose a niche, create designs that sell, set up a store, write listings that get found, and market your way to passive product income without ever holding stock.

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Print on Demand

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A note before you begin

Print on demand (POD) lets you sell t-shirts, mugs, posters and more without buying stock, printing anything, or shipping a single parcel. A platform prints and ships each item only after a customer orders. You supply the design and the marketing; they handle the rest.

This is one of the few online businesses where a beginner with a laptop and taste can compete globally. It is not free money - designs and marketing decide success - but the risk is tiny because you never pay for stock that might not sell.

Treat it as a design-and-marketing business. The people who win create many designs, study what sells, and keep improving. Start simple, publish, and learn from real sales.

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Introduction to print on demand

In POD, you upload a design, place it on products in an online catalogue, and list them for sale. When someone buys, the platform prints your design on the item and ships it directly to the customer. You keep the difference between the base cost and your selling price. No upfront stock, no storage, no shipping headaches.

The trade-off for this low risk is lower profit per item and heavy competition, so volume and good marketing matter. Some platforms (like Redbubble) also bring their own shoppers, which is perfect for beginners; others require you to drive all the traffic yourself. Understanding this model clearly is the first step to using it well.

IN PRACTICE

A designer uploads one funny slogan design and places it on shirts, mugs and stickers. Over months, with no stock and no shipping on her side, those listings quietly sell to buyers around the world while she creates more.

TRY THIS

Browse a POD marketplace like Redbubble. Find three best-selling designs and note what they have in common (style, humour, niche, simplicity).

Key takeaways

- No stock, no shipping - the platform fulfils orders.
- Low risk, but lower margins and high competition.
- Marketplace platforms bring built-in shoppers.

Choosing your niche

Generic designs get lost; niche designs get bought. A niche is a specific group with a shared identity or interest - nurses, cat lovers, gym-goers, a hobby, a profession, a hometown pride. People love wearing what says 'this is me,' and they search for exactly that. A tight niche makes both your designs and your marketing far easier.

Pick niches with passion and spending power, and ideally ones you understand, so your designs feel authentic rather than generic. You can serve several small niches over time. Avoid trademarked names, logos and slogans - using protected brands will get your account banned, so create original work around themes, not brands.

IN PRACTICE

'Funny t-shirt' is hopeless in search. 'Sarcastic nurse t-shirt' finds a passionate, specific buyer who feels seen - and happily pays. The narrower the identity, the easier the sale.

TRY THIS

List five niches you understand or belong to. For each, write one design idea that people in that group would proudly wear.

Key takeaways

- Specific niches sell; generic designs get lost.
- People buy designs that say 'this is me'.
- Never use trademarked brands - originals only.

Design basics for POD

You do not need to be a trained artist. Many top-selling POD designs are simple: a clever phrase in a nice font, clean typography, or a minimal graphic. Free and low-cost tools like Canva let anyone create sellable designs. What matters is a clear idea, readable text, and a look that suits the niche and product.

Learn the technical basics: designs need to be high resolution, usually with a transparent background, and sized correctly for the product. A great idea ruined by a blurry or badly-placed image will not sell. Keep designs clean and legible even as a small thumbnail, because that is how buyers first see them.

IN PRACTICE

One of the best-selling POD styles is just bold text: a relatable phrase in a strong font on a plain background. No drawing skill needed - just wit, clean typography and the right niche.

TRY THIS

Create three simple text-based designs in Canva for your chosen niche. Export them high-resolution with a transparent background.

Key takeaways

- Simple, clever designs sell - artistry optional.
- Use free tools like Canva.
- High resolution and correct sizing are essential.

Setting up on Redbubble

Redbubble is beginner-friendly because it hosts your products, prints, ships and even brings shoppers through its own marketplace search. You create a free account, set up your shop, and upload designs, placing each on the products you choose. This is the fastest way to get your first sales without needing your own website or traffic.

Fill your profile and shop properly - a clear name, banner and bio build trust. Enable the products that suit each design (a wordy joke works on shirts and mugs; a detailed graphic suits posters). Set your profit margin sensibly: too high and nothing sells, too low and it is not worth it. You can adjust as you learn.

IN PRACTICE

A learner set up a Redbubble shop in an afternoon, uploaded ten designs across shirts and stickers, and made her first international sale within weeks - purely from Redbubble's own search traffic, with no outside marketing.

TRY THIS

Create a Redbubble account, complete your shop profile, and upload your three designs onto suitable products with a sensible margin.

Key takeaways

- Redbubble prints, ships and brings shoppers.
- A complete profile builds buyer trust.
- Match each design to suitable products; set margins wisely.

Creating listings that sell

On marketplaces, most sales come from search, so your listing text is your marketing. Use clear, keyword-rich titles and tags that describe exactly what the design is and who it is for ('funny nurse mug gift for night shift'). Think like the buyer: what words would they type? Fill every tag with relevant terms - this is how the platform matches you to shoppers.

Good visuals close the sale. Use the platform's mockups so buyers see the design on a real-looking product, and make sure it looks great as a small thumbnail. A strong title, complete tags and clean mockups turn a hidden design into a findable, buyable product.

IN PRACTICE

Two identical designs, different listings. The one with a vague title 'Cool Design 1' never sold; the one titled and tagged 'Funny Teacher Appreciation Gift T-Shirt' started selling - because buyers could finally find it.

TRY THIS

Write a keyword-rich title and a full set of tags for each of your designs, imagining the exact words your buyer would search.

Key takeaways

- Listings are your marketing - write for search.
- Fill titles and tags with buyer keywords.
- Clean mockups and thumbnails close the sale.

Marketing your store

Marketplace search alone can bring sales, but marketing multiplies them. Share your designs on social media where your niche gathers - a nurses' design in nursing groups, a gym design on fitness pages. Content showing the products in real life (photos, short videos) drives clicks. You become your own free advertising channel.

Building a small audience around your niche pays long-term: an Instagram or TikTok page for your design theme brings repeat buyers and lets you launch new designs to warm fans. Marketing is also feedback - watch which designs people react to and make more like them. Selling and listening go together.

IN PRACTICE

A creator posted her hiking-themed designs in outdoor Facebook groups and on a small Instagram page. Those free posts, not the marketplace search, became her biggest source of sales - and her followers requested new designs she then made and sold.

TRY THIS

Share one of your designs in a relevant online community or on a niche social page. Note any clicks, feedback or sales it brings.

Key takeaways

- Marketing multiplies marketplace sales.
- Share where your niche already gathers.
- A niche audience brings repeat buyers and ideas.

Scaling your income

POD is a numbers game: more good designs across more products and niches means more chances to be found and bought. Once you know what sells, batch-create designs in your winning styles and niches. Many part-time POD sellers grow simply by consistently uploading, keeping the winners, and dropping the duds.

Scale smart, not just big. Double down on your best-performing niches and design styles rather than spreading thin. Consider expanding to other platforms (some let you sell on your own store or via Etsy) once you have proven designs. Reinvest a little time or money into better design tools as your income grows.

IN PRACTICE

A seller noticed that of her 50 designs, five made most of the sales - all in one niche and style. She made twenty more like those five, and her income climbed, because she followed the data instead of her guesses.

TRY THIS

Once you have some sales, identify your best niche/style. Create five new designs in that exact lane and publish them.

Key takeaways

- More quality designs = more chances to sell.
- Double down on proven niches and styles.
- Follow the data, not your guesses.

Launch your POD store

Your final project is a live store with a real set of designs - enough to look established and give the platform's search something to work with. Do not wait for perfect designs; publish a solid batch, then keep adding. A live store that exists and sells beats a perfect one still in your imagination.

Then run the loop that builds real income: create, list well, market a little, watch the data, and make more of what works. POD rewards patience and consistency over months, not days. Keep uploading, keep learning from sales, and the passive income slowly compounds as your catalogue grows.

IN PRACTICE

A learner launched with fifteen designs and committed to adding five a week. Sales were quiet for a month, then steadily grew as her catalogue and best-sellers built up - the classic POD curve for those who don't quit early.

TRY THIS

Launch your store with at least ten designs across suitable products. Commit to adding a few new designs each week for the next month.

Key takeaways

- Launch with a solid batch, then keep adding.
- Run the create-list-market-review loop.
- POD rewards patience and a growing catalogue.

KEEP GOING

Skills pay for life. Now go use them.

Finishing the reading is not the goal - finishing the project is. Pick the one exercise in this book that scared you most and do it this week. Then bring your work to your CHRISCO facilitator or post it online. That single habit - shipping real work - is what separates the youth who earn from the youth who only dream.

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